PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Black Officeholders — A House Divided

When the Lawmakers Looked Like the People

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Black Officeholders — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Significance asks what changed, and what deserves remembering. Weigh this first for yourself

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · C.1870 — Senator Hiram Revels



Hiram Rhodes Revels of Mississippi, the first Black U.S. Senator — photograph, Brady–Handy studio, c.1870, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · THE RECORD OF BLACK OFFICEHOLDING — The numbers

~2,000 Black men held office during Reconstruction · 16 served in Congress · Hiram Revels (1870) was the first Black U.S. Senator · Blanche K. Bruce served a full Senate term · for a time Black representatives were a majority in South Carolina's lower house.
— summarized from the historical record. Public domain

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YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · WHAT WAS NEW

Why was it so remarkable that Hiram Revels took a U.S. Senate seat in 1870 — especially the seat once held by Jefferson Davis?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · WHY THE ERASURE

Why would opponents later spread the false claim that these biracial governments were corrupt and incompetent?

- ☐ A. because the governments really did nothing
- ☐ B. to justify stripping Black Americans of the vote and power
- ☐ C. because no one remembered them
- ☐ D. to praise Reconstruction

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · GOVERNING FOR ALL

Black lawmakers pushed for things like public schools that helped everyone, not only Black citizens. Why is that detail important to understanding their significance?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · WHY REMEMBER IT

In three or four sentences, explain why recovering the true story of Black officeholders is historically significant — both for understanding Reconstruction and for understanding the long fight for equality.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Black Officeholders — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "It was remarkable because… The Jefferson Davis connection shows…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. to justify stripping Black Americans of the vote and power**

Right. If you could convince people Black governance had "failed," you could justify taking the vote and power away from Black citizens. The myth served the goal of white supremacy.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "It matters that they governed for all because…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "This story is significant because…"